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One Of The Girls

Early the next morning, I spotted Emma as she passed my office.

"Hey Watson!" I called out.

She backtracked and stuck her head in the door frame. I waved her in and asked her to shut the door.

Her eyes widened a bit because the door to my office is almost never closed, but I motioned for her not to worry.

"I just don't want Danni to overhear," I said once the door was closed.

That didn't appear to make her feel better, but she took a seat anyway.

"What's up?" she asked.

"Couple of things. First, what in the hell did you say to those kids yesterday?"

She smiled.

"I think that should stay between the four of us," she said. "Let's just say it was a fruitful discussion."

"One that went well beyond just telling them the story," I said.

"We talked about a lot of things," she said. "Like I said, it was good. And, honestly, I think they're going to be fine. They just need to settle in a little."

"They've had a year to settle in."

"Yeah, but I don't think they had the right person helping them," she countered.

I raised my eyebrows.

"Tiz is gonna be offended."

"I'm not talking about Tiz," she said.

I puzzled things a bit more, then my eyebrows went up another notch.

"Steph?"

She gave a subtle nod.

"I love Steph, and none of us would be where we are without her. But, let's face it, she's not exactly..."

"Human?"

"I was gonna go with 'personable,' but I guess that works."

I had to admit it was a fair point. Though I realize her manner isn't all that warm, I expected Steph's reputation to be enough for the younger fighters. That they would let her teach them to win, which, in turn, would win them over. But it hadn't worked out that way because there was more going on than I'd realized.

"I think they respect her, and I think they will come to understand how much they need her," Emma continued, "but I also think she scares them a little bit."

Steph McMahon? Scary? Say it ain't so.

"Well, whatever you said, it was effective. They seem tuned in now."

"Give us time," she said. "We'll have them fitting in just fine."

"Us?"

"Yeah. A few of us talked it over and decided it's time to get the little ones initiated. Make them part of the club."

No doubt, the few included the likes of Tiz, J-Law and Anna Kendrick. The very same women who seemed to intimidate the rookies most.

It occurred to me then that the same character traits that made those women successful in almost everything they did were the reasons I knew they could be trusted to help tear down the wall the younger fighters had built around themselves.

I was also beginning to realize that I couldn't invent enough positions to reward all the leaders I had on my roster.

"Initiated?" I asked.

She gave me nothing but that sly smirk of hers. Guess I was going to have to wait and see.

"No one's gonna get hurt, right?" I asked.

She rolled her eyes.

"We're just taking them out tomorrow night. Maybe have a little fun with them."

"Gee, why doesn't that make me feel better?"

"Have a little faith in us."

"Hmm. I suppose I wouldn't have called you in yesterday if I didn't."

We shared a look that said I meant it and she believed me, and left it at that.

"So, if that was first on your list, what's second?" she prompted.

"Danni," I answered. "You guys worked her over pretty good yesterday."

"Maybe you weren't watching closely enough, but she got her licks in, too."

"You know exactly what I mean. First you, then Aly, then Emily. All three times, you guys were going at it like you meant it."

"Don't be ridiculous," she said. "We would never hurt her."

"We both know you can't guarantee that," I said. "You get tired, you slip up... anything can happen."

"We were just having a little fun."

"A little too much fun. Remember you only got in there once. Danni was involved in all three. How would you feel if I lined you up against Aly, Em and Danni in quick succession?"

She made a face that said she didn't find the idea particularly appealing.

"You guys wore her out, yesterday."

"Maybe we went a little overboard," she said, "but do you realize how rare this is for us?"

I did not, so I waited for her to explain.

"Danni always sort of rides above everything."

Now it was my turn to make a face, but she waved me off before I could protest.

"I don't mean it that way," she said. "It's not like she's too good for us, or anything. She's just busy, you know? She never has a lot of time to just hang out. To be one of the girls. Team prep is the only time we get to do this with her, and after what happened... this is the first chance most of us are getting to really get involved with all that."

I nodded, though I was a little surprised by the idea that Danni didn't often get to be one of the girls. Was that really true? It seemed to me she was always out there and involved in everything, but, for Emma to say it... it was something to think about, anyway.

"Look, I get it," I said, "but that was too much yesterday. And it caused her to skip our workout, too."

She understood the weight of that immediately.

"Oh," she said apologetically.

"Damn right, oh," I said with a smile. "All I'm saying is that you guys need to back off a little, and save a piece of her for me, you know?"

She returned the smile.

"I guess we can do that."

"I appreciate it," I said. "Now get out of my office. This discussion has been far too friendly. Too much of this kind of thing could ruin our relationship."

"I couldn't agree more."

Then she paused on her way out.

"Danni's game is incredible," she mused.

"I know," I said. "I'm reminded of it every day."

"She took on all three of us, and STILL managed to knock Emily on her ass in the last one."

I shrugged, as if to say, what can I tell you?

She nodded, then seemed to disappear into her thoughts for a moment.

"What happened against Cole..." she began.

"...isn't going to happen again," I finished.

Emma's head began to shake. Slowly at first, then more firmly.

"Not a chance," she said.

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The weeks that followed brought a new normal to RSI. I worked the rookies like dogs, and they never whined a bit. They had a lot of ground to make up, and they seemed to know it. Though they still seemed to feel out of place at times, they didn't let that stop them. They were beginning to gel with the stable as a whole, and their relationships with their teammates were warming rapidly. In the meantime, they seemed to have finally remembered why they were here in the first place.

Danni, meanwhile, was still getting picked on by her fellow fighters, and, to be honest, she seemed to be loving it. Though it still made little sense to me, it became clear that Emma was right. The smile on Danni's face was brighter and more frequent than I could ever remember. Clearly, this wasn't something she got to do very often, and she was enjoying every second of it.

Then, just as it seemed we were humming along, we ran out of time. The team event was upon us, and it was time for our senior fighters - most notably Danni - to prove themselves in the cage, once again.